



QUALITATIVE RESEARCH INSIGHTS

The people with the most tools for connecting have the least connection.

Research on young adult social life, and why it isn't working

MAX SAMBERG · SUMMER 2026

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BACKGROUND

Where we stand today

The “anxious generation” grew up

Gen Z — born between 1997–2012 — are now independent young adults, struggling with mental health issues

73–79%

of Gen Z report loneliness — the highest of any generation

61%

of 18–25s report serious loneliness

29-36%

depression and anxiety among 18–25s — worse than teens

58%

say they lack meaning or purpose

And the problems are not just a result of COVID

Weekly time with friends, ages 18–29

12.8 → 6.5 hrs (2010–2019)

Daily in-person socializing, ages 15–24

60 → 35 min (2005–2025)

Americans with 10+ close friends

33% → 13% (1990–2021)

Time with friends halved before COVID, then dropped to as low as **4.2 hours** in 2020. Now it sits at **5 hours** per week. Reopening only gave back a fraction.

Whatever broke is structural.

THIS IS A SERIOUS HEALTH PROBLEM, NOT A TREND

People with weak social relationships are
50% more likely to die early than those with
strong ones

— HOLT-LUNSTAD ET AL., PLOS MEDICINE (148 STUDIES, 308,000 PEOPLE)

Meanwhile, drinking has collapsed, but not the bar

54%

of U.S. adults drink — a 90-year low

50%

of 18–34s don't drink at all — from the most likely age group to the least

72% → 58% → 50%

share of 18–34s who drink, 2001 · 2023 · 2026

PEOPLE STOPPED WANTING WHAT BARS
SELL, BUT KEEP GOING ANYWAY

Bars

FLAT

Bowling alleys, theaters,
social clubs

–20–33%

Every comparable venue lost traffic.
The bar held.

Proposed solutions aim at children, not young adults

Phone bans

Screen-time limits

Delayed smartphones

Reformed childhoods

Nobody is building for the generation that already lived it — now independent young adults, without school, teams, or dorms to facilitate connection.

HOWEVER, YOUNG ADULTS ARE MANUFACTURING THEIR OWN ANSWER

22.9% → 30.8%

percentage US gym members belonging to the under-25 age group, 2015-2024

+3.5x

run clubs on Strava, 2024-2025

Recurring, active, affordable — the shape of the social world young adults build themselves.

THE PROBLEM

Young adults go out to connect — to engage in conversation, do something different, be around other people — but the default venue (the bar) fails to provide a fulfilling social experience.

WHY IT PERSISTS

The bar's real product was never alcohol. It's the guarantee that people will be there, talking to strangers is normal, and nobody has to plan anything.

WHY SOLUTIONS ARE FAILING

Most solutions are one-off events or discovery platforms. Events end, and the problem for young adults is not discovery. Conversely, bars are repeatable and accessible without organization.

THE RESULT

No alternatives carry the guarantee of social density into something people actually want to be doing. So the only alternative to a night that doesn't deliver is staying home.

THE COLLISION

The loneliest cohort in modern history, whose only remaining default social venue is the bar, is drinking less than ever before and is starved for social connection.

**BUT NOBODY HAS BUILT
THE REPLACEMENT.** *yet.*

THE SOCIAL INFRASTRUCTURE “GAP YEARS”

Two stages of life build relationships for you. Between those two chapters, however, young adults are on their own.

COLLEGE

Same life stage

Same places

Same infrastructure

*Dorms • dining halls • clubs •
classes • parties*

THE “GAP YEARS”

The freest years of your life – and the emptiest.

Various life stages

Many different places

No infrastructure

*Bars • dating apps • social media • one-off
events • discovery platforms*

PARENTHOOD

Same life stage

Same places

Same infrastructure

*School pickup • playgrounds •
sports sidelines • birthday
parties • parent groups*

The gap isn't new. The conditions are.

What filled it is emptying out. What replaced it doesn't compound.

● BACKGROUND • WHY ME

I hit the same wall in three cities

New York • **NY**

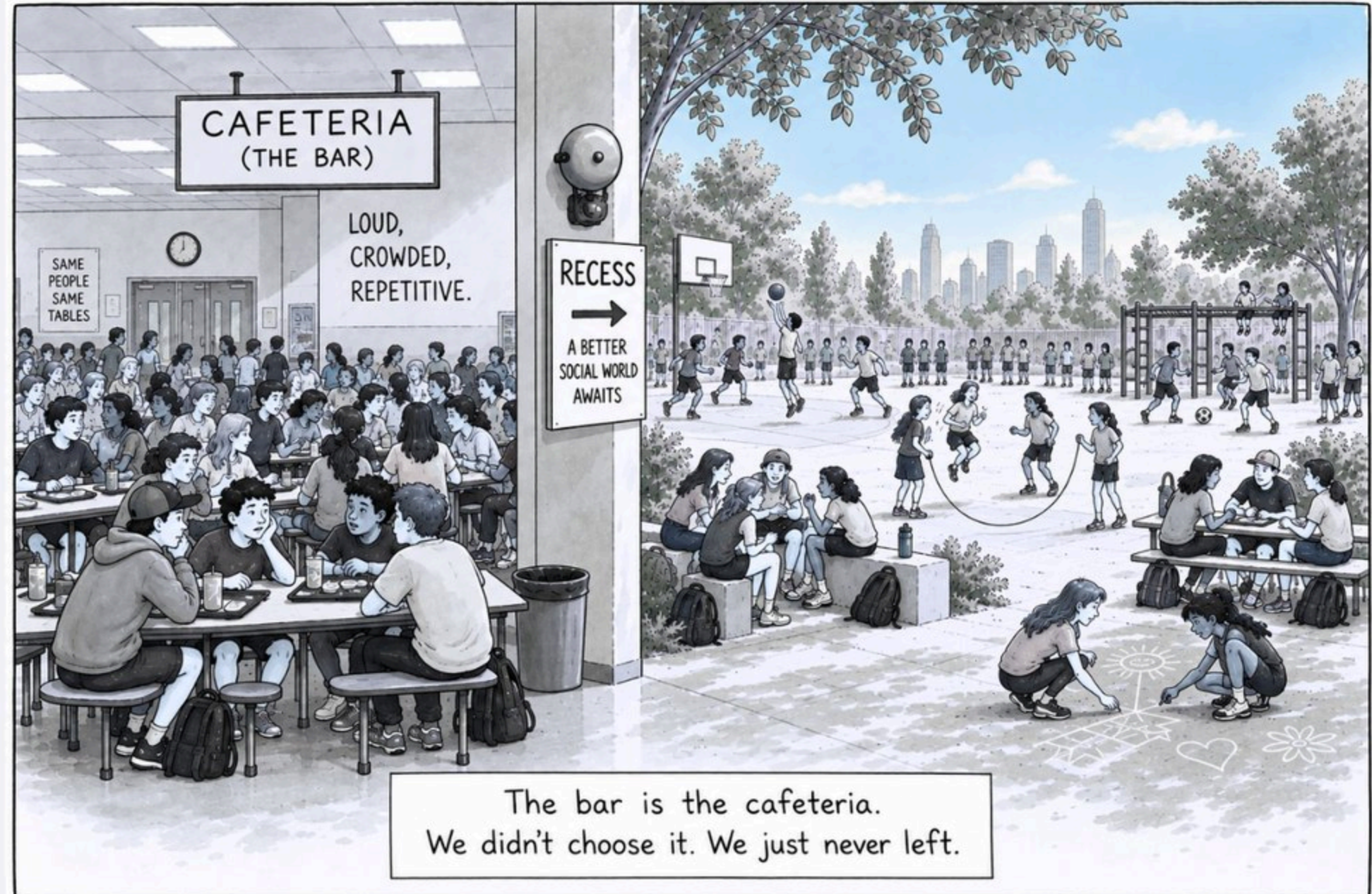
*With friends.
Every plan was a bar.*

Southeast Asia

*Alone.
No easy alternatives.*

Los Angeles • **CA**

*New city, not drinking.
Nowhere to go.*



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THE RESEARCH

What I did

What I set out to learn

- | | | |
|-----------|---------------------|---|
| 01 | Formation | How do adult friendships actually form? |
| 02 | Revealed preference | What do people actually want to do — and what are they already doing instead of bars? |
| 03 | Decision friction | What tips go-out vs. stay-in? What's hardest about making plans? |
| 04 | Technology | Where does it help, and where does it fail? |
| 05 | Unmet demand | What communities are people looking for, and what do they wish existed? |
-

How I gathered information

To educate myself on the space, I conducted multiple streams of research methodology

SECONDARY RESEARCH

Academic literature, trade press, *The Anxious Generation*, the history of third places

COGNITIVE EXERCISES

Thought exercises, pressure testing, personal conversations, research blogs

PRIMARY RESEARCH

A 7-question qualitative survey — every question open-ended

Primary research — who I talked to

n=20

AGES 23–28 · 14 MEN, 6 WOMEN

NYC · LA · SF · San Diego · Chicago · Syracuse · Atlanta

Friends and friends-of-friends

Directional signal, not statistical proof.

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INSIGHTS

Formation · Revealed preference · Decision friction · Technology

FORMATION — THE HEADLINE FINDING

0 of 20

Not one person made a friend at a bar.

Friendships form in recurring formats

Sports leagues and gyms

Work and internships

School and grad school

Neighbors, roommates, mutual friends

~~Bars~~ **NEVER NAMED**

Every setting people named was one they returned to.

Meeting people isn't hard — making new friends is

“I don't necessarily think meeting new people is so hard, but actually making them friends is hard. There is no forced togetherness... time exposed to another person is seemingly directly proportional to closeness.”

— 27, SYRACUSE

CONTEXT

Unprompted, he described **the exposure effect** — the same mechanism the literature puts at roughly 200 hours to a close friend.

He played a full men's-league basketball season and stayed in touch with nobody. Once a week, that's it. **No relationship.**

Episodic means nothing compounds.
Events can't dethrone infrastructure.

Friend groups don't merge

“When going out I'm typically with a group of friends and other people are with friends — and it's rare that separate friend groups commingle.”

25, NEW YORK CITY

**THE PROBLEM ISN'T THAT PEOPLE ARE ALONE.
IT'S THAT THE GROUPS NEVER TOUCH.**

What people do instead of bars

Sports and leagues

Gyms, run clubs, surf

Hosting dinners

Cards and games

THE IDEAL DAY, AS DESCRIBED BY THE RESPONDENTS

1

Solo morning ritual

2

Active play with friends

3

A shared meal

4

Games at night

People mentioned golf, hoops, spikeball, surf, beach, run, grill, potluck, cards, board games.

Alcohol appears — incidentally. It is never the point.

*Everyone agrees:
more of this*

The default is staying in

WHAT KEEPS THEM HOME

Cost

Fatigue

Hangover math

The same plan as always

WHAT GETS THEM OUT

A known crew

Something genuinely new

Proximity

Most people would choose to stay in — unless there's something new to do, or visibility on the plans and the people.

The choice isn't bar vs. better option. It's bar vs. the couch — and for young adults, the couch is winning.

Open to new people, wary of strangers

“You start with a team of friends, so you automatically have at least 3 friends... it was awesome to meet new people when I was already in the comfort of my friends.”

— 24, LOS ANGELES

CONTEXT

For women this is safety, not preference: "as a small woman I am always on alert" · **"friends of friends — not strangers."**

The scavenger-hunt company she's describing seeds every team with people you already know. The **warm-entry model**, already validated in the wild.

Every path to someone new ran through someone already known.

Discovery is not the bottleneck

“There are a million things happening, then I get overwhelmed, and then I don't know anyone going — so at the same time it feels like there is nothing.”

24, LOS ANGELES

PEOPLE ARE FLOODED, NOT STARVED.

Another events feed solves a problem nobody has.

Apps are good at logistics, bad at people

WHERE TECHNOLOGY HELPS

Concerts and live events

Texting to coordinate

Social media for discovery

Finding things

WHERE TECHNOLOGY HURTS

Bad recommendations

Too many options

Can't find the right people

Everyone wants to rely on it less

“It's easy to find things to do. Not as easy to find people to do them with.”

The one app that's working — and where it stops

Partiful is a free invite app that has become the default way young people send and RSVP to parties.

WHAT PARTIFUL GETS RIGHT

The only app multiple people volunteered as useful

A visible guest list — you know who'll be there

Friends-of-friends by construction

Being used for connection more and more

AND WHERE IT STOPS

It organises the invite, not the occasion

No activity — so no shared object of attention

You end up talking to the people you came with

One-off — nothing recurs, nothing compounds

A BAR WITH BETTER INVITATIONS.

Clearly the right direction — clearly not the answer.

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OPPORTUNITIES

The conclusions we came to and our thesis on what the findings tell us

01 BACKGROUND

02 THE RESEARCH

03 INSIGHTS

04 OPPORTUNITIES

05 LOOKING AHEAD

The four core problems

1

Finding **the right people** who want to do the same things

2

Not trusting that events or apps have the right people

3

Starting conversations with people and groups you don't know

4

Cost and coordination — going out is expensive and hard to organize

The bar's product was never alcohol.
It's the guarantee that people will be there.

DENSITY — Someone is always there

PERMISSION — Talking to a stranger is normal there, and almost nowhere else

FAMILIARITY — You know what you're walking into

LEGIBILITY — "Want to grab a drink?" needs no explanation

ZERO COORDINATION — No plan, no roster, no RSVP

The middle ground

Two options that fail in opposite directions, and one clear opportunity for a solution

BARS

Strangers · no shared interest ·
alcohol-centered

THE MIDDLE

New people, through
shared activities, with
people you half-know.

STAYING IN

Close friends only · nobody new

People don't go out to drink, they go out to connect!

Why nothing existing fills the middle

MEETUP

Nobody our age uses it,
or even knows of it

EVENTBRITE

Discovery only —
more scrolling, no
connection

PARTIFUL

Closest thing — warm
list, no activity, no
second time

BUMBLE BFF, TIMELEFT, POSH

Matching strangers,
one meeting at a time

Every alternative is episodic.

None of them bring the same people back the next one.

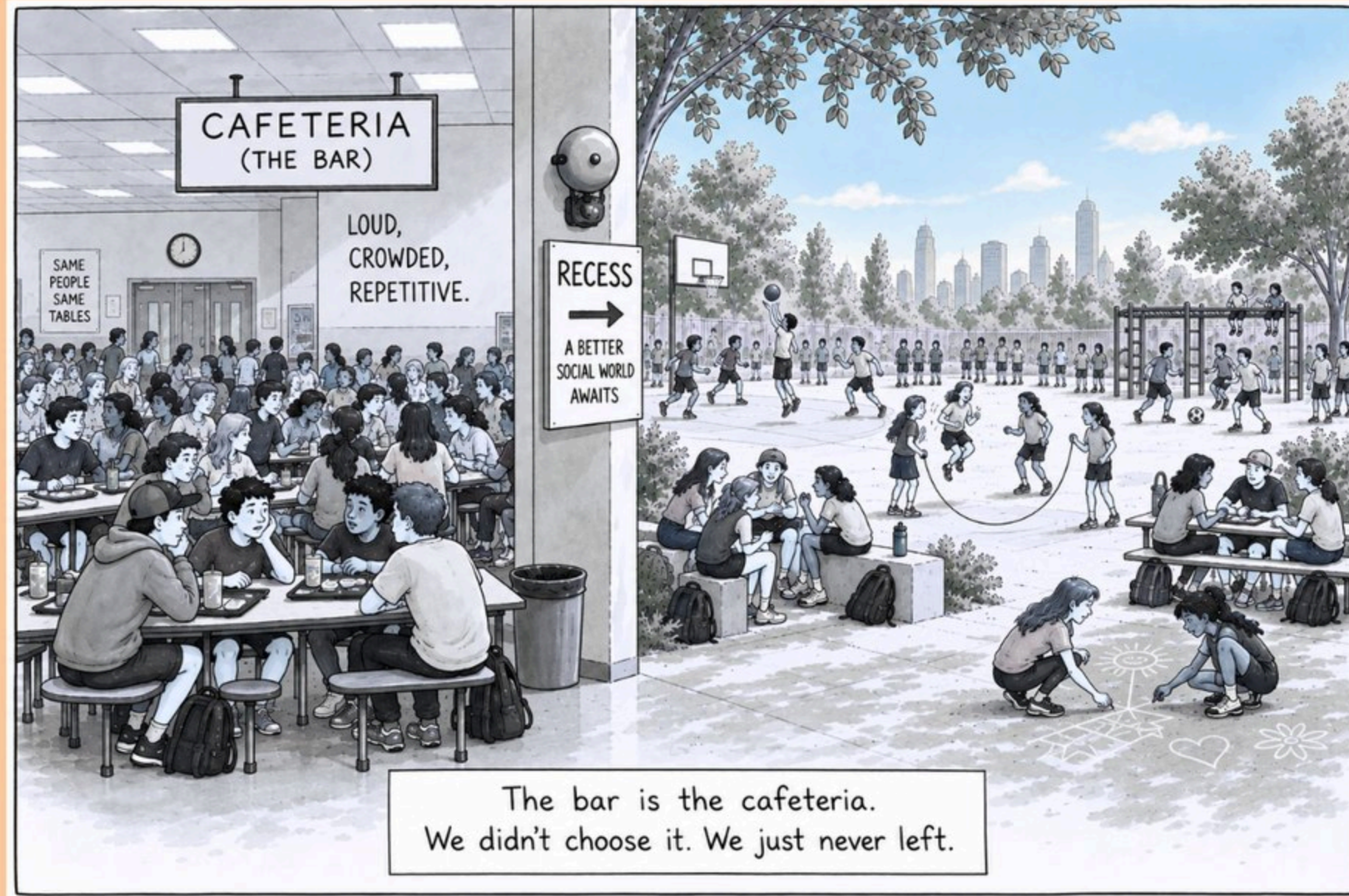
THE CHASM

Some people already solve this — they join the run club, start the league, host the dinner. But most people don't.

THE EARLY ADOPTERS WERE NEVER THE PROBLEM.

The default is.

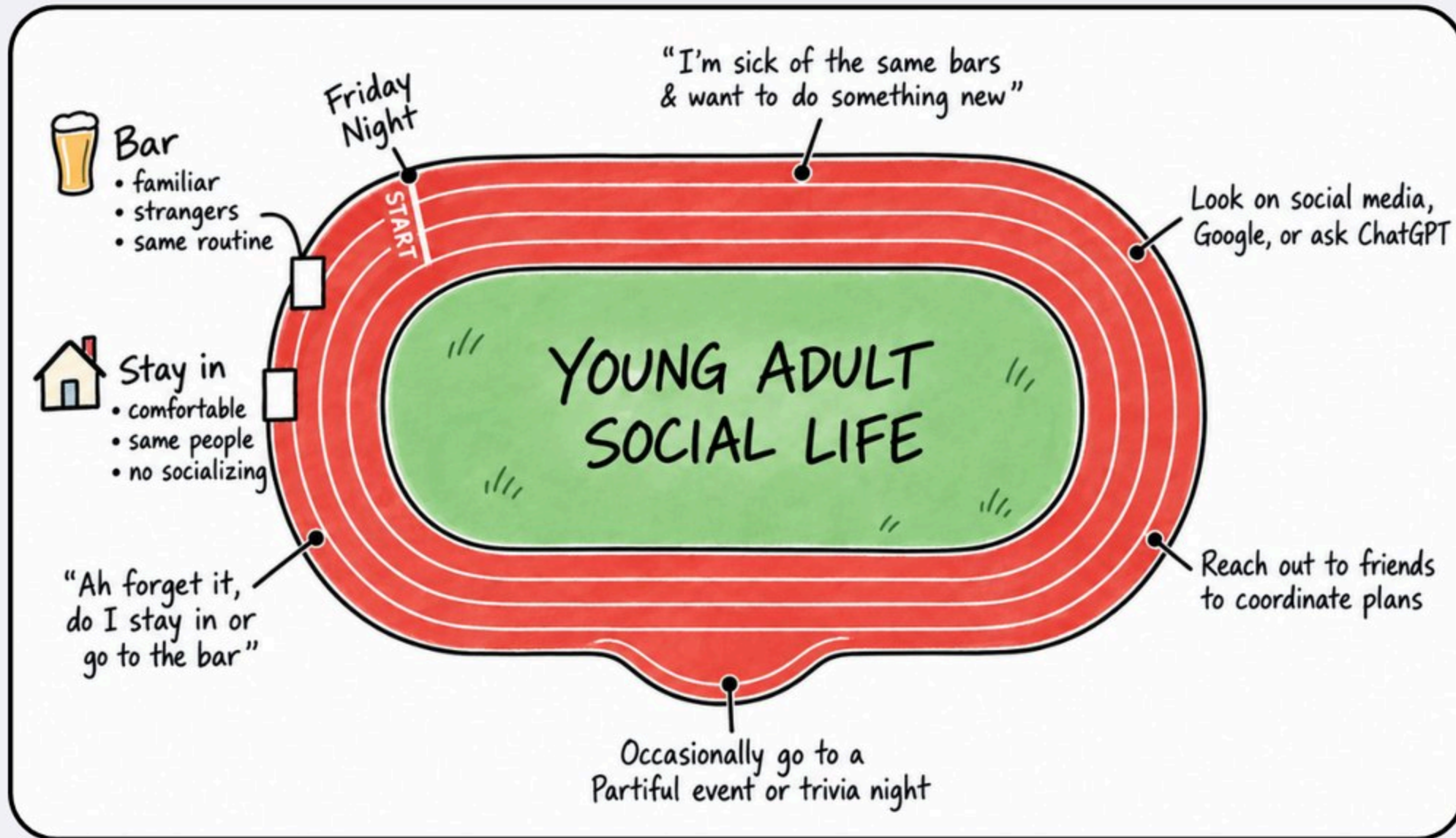
THE CHASM



Some kids leave the cafeteria early to go play flag football. Maybe a few follow.

But the rest of us wait for the whole class.

The weekend loop



Same loop, over and over again — we never leave the track.

Stay in enough times and the track starts to feel like a treadmill.

For better social connection, there must be an easier way for young adults to step off the track and onto an open road full of possibilities.

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LOOKING AHEAD

The lesson, the bet, and who we're building for

THE LESSON

Our generation wants community. We have *no infrastructure* for it.

- The people willing to build their own infrastructure can find it — everyone else continues to go to the bars or opts for staying home. The result is disconnection.

The bet

If something offered repeated exposure to the same people, through shared experiences, and real conversation — with the same certainty a bar offers — young adults would substitute it for a meaningful share of their nights out.

THE OCCASION

FRIDAY NIGHT.

Every alternative is an event or a Tuesday.
Nobody is offering a substitute to a Friday night at the bar.

THE OPEN QUESTION

DENSITY.

How many people, of what kind, at what hour, before a room feels alive — and who shows up before it does.

Who we're building for

MARCUS, 27 NEW YORK CITY

Four days in the office. His closest friends are colleagues and the guys from men's league — and he's in touch with none of the league.

Loves playing sports

Drinks, but is tired of it being the plan

Wants a crew, not a calendar

“It’s usually just once a week, then see ya.”

LIZ, 24 LOS ANGELES

Moved for work a year ago. Finds a million things happening and knows nobody going to any of them.

Runs, hosts dinners, doesn't really drink

Won't go where it's all strangers

Will go anywhere a friend-of-a-friend vouches for

“Nothing with strangers. I'm always on alert.”



Let us live in a world where, on a Friday night, people are comfortable doing things they actually want to do — where there are options for social connection tied to their personal interests, where they can share experiences with similar people doing that same thing.

The infrastructure for social connection among young adults is ripe for reinvention.

Let's build it!